

Session 7: The Purpose of Light on Day One

Key Takeaways

- The creation of light and its separation from darkness generates the fundamental order of time that governs the rest of the chapter—day and night.
- The light of Genesis 1 is called “day.” Day is a period of time that then gets used throughout the rest of the chapter. For example, “It was evening, it was morning, day one.”
- Rather than recounting the creation of photons, the narrative portrays the creation of light as the fundamental order of time so that life can flourish and the narrative can progress.

The Creation of Light in Genesis 1:3-5

In [Genesis 1:3-5](#), we read about the creation of light. Genesis 1:3 reads, “Let there be light” (יהי אור). But what is actually being created here?

In modern cosmologies, light consists of photons, tiny packets of energy that behave like a wave and also as particles. When we (living in modern society) read that light is created in Genesis 1, this is what might come to our minds. But is that how the biblical authors understood light? Let’s take a closer look.

In Genesis 1:5, we are told what is being created. The light is called “day,” and the darkness is called “night.” Are day and night material entities? We likely wouldn’t describe these as material entities, such as protons and particles, but as periods of time. Light here is not a thing that is brought into existence at a specific moment in time. Rather, on day one, the order of time is named into meaningful and functional existence.

Think for a moment about what is missing. According to the text, have the sun, moon, or stars been created yet? They haven’t! So where does this light come from? The light is emanating from God himself. Later biblical authors understood that the light of Genesis 1 is God’s glorious being, emanating into the darkness to bring order (e.g., [Ps. 36:5-9](#); [Isa. 60:19-20](#); [Rev. 22:5](#)).

A Thesis on the Meaning of Genesis 1

“The early chapters of Genesis accurately present accounts of cosmic and human origins in the language and conceptual categories of the ancient Israelite authors of the Bible. These texts should not be removed from their ancient context and read as if they describe cosmic or human origins in 21st century scientific terms. They speak in terms of an ancient Near Eastern perception of the world, and should be interpreted within that setting. When we discern the meaning of the texts in their ancient context, we find that they constitute a worldview statement about God and his relationship to the world, and about humans and their relation to God and the world. This basic worldview statement transcends its ancient cultural setting, and commands the attention of God’s people in all places and all times.”

Worldview

A worldview is a comprehensive and cosmic story through which a cultural group orders and makes sense of their life experience. Worldviews answer the basic questions of human existence. Questions such as:

1. Who are we?
2. Where are we?
3. What is the problem?
4. What is the solution?
5. Where are we located in the story?

Genesis 1 is designed to answer these core questions. And we are going to tackle these questions in three large steps.

1. *"Where are we?"* We will examine this question by observing the world picture of Genesis 1 (i.e., cosmology).
2. *"Who are we?"* We will examine this question by observing the creation of humanity in Genesis 1 (i.e., anthropology).
3. *"Where are we located in the story?"* We will examine this question by observing the creation of time in Genesis 1 (i.e., eschatology).

Seeking to understand the worldview of the biblical authors is an important step in discerning the meaning of the biblical texts in their ancient contexts.

Reflection Question

In Genesis 1:3-5, light is created. What is this light named? And is the account of light's creation about material being created (like photons) or the purpose of light?